



BEFORE

In 1858, the year the ruling Democratic Party lost control of Congress, many Republicans made powerful speeches on how the issue of slavery divided the nation.

HALF SLAVE AND HALF FREE

Most famous of these speeches was **Abraham Lincoln's "House Divided" speech** delivered in Springfield, Illinois, in May 1858, in which he declared, "I believe this government cannot endure, permanently **half slave and half free**." The speech went on to refer to the situation in [Kansas](#) and the upholding of the **Dred Scott decision** (see [The Dred Scott case](#)).

IRREPRESSIBLE CONFLICT

Even more inflammatory was a speech delivered by New York **Senator William Seward** in October 1858 in Rochester. He argued that an "**irrepressible conflict**" existed within the country. The nation "must and will ... become **either entirely a slave-holding nation or a free-labor nation**." Democrats condemned the speech as dangerous agitation and when, a year later, John Brown led the attack on Harpers Ferry, **Northern Democratic and Southern newspapers blamed Seward's theory** of an "irrepressible conflict" for Brown's actions.

Within 12 hours of Brown's raid, militia and locals trapped him and his men in the federal armory's fire engine house. By midnight the next day, Colonel Robert E. Lee arrived with 87 Marines to rescue the hostages and subdue the raiders. Brown refused to surrender and the Marines rushed the engine house, battering down the door, killing or wounding many of the remaining raiders, and collecting the hostages unharmed.